

SESSION 2 — CORE STABILITY AND UPPER BODY

60 minutes · calisthenics bias · moderate nervous-system cost · needs a bar, a bench, a band, a post or tree to aim a point at

A fencer's trunk does one job above all others: it stops the torso moving when the legs and the weapon arm do. Almost nothing in this session is a crunch. Everything is a hold, an anti-rotation, or a press or pull done without letting the middle leak.

This is the session that can be run the day after a hard one, and the one that survives bad weather under a shelter.

Marker for the log: total strict pull-ups across the four rounds of block A, plus the longest clean hollow hold in block C.

Stop rule: any hold that starts to sag is over — the next second of a sagging plank trains sagging. End the set and move on.

Minute by minute



TIME	BLOCK	WORK AND REST
0:00-0:04	Raise	Brisk walk into an easy jog, then jacks and arm circles · easy throughout
0:04-0:09	Mobility	Five movements, one minute each · easy throughout
0:09-0:13	Activation	2 rounds of 2 min · 90 s work / 30 s rest
0:13-0:25	A — Pull	4 rounds of 3 min · 90 s work / 90 s rest
0:25-0:37	B — Press and anti-rotation	4 rounds of 3 min · 100 s work / 80 s rest
0:37-0:47	C — Trunk ladder	2 rounds of 5 min · 240 s work / 60 s rest
0:47-0:54	D — Fencing transfer	4 rounds of 1:45 · 90 s work / 15 s rest
0:54-0:57	Finisher	Grip, 3 rounds · 30 s work / 30 s rest
0:57-1:00	Cool-down	Stretch and breathe · easy throughout

0:00–0:04 · Raise

Easy throughout

Two minutes brisk walking into an easy jog. Then 20 jumping jacks, 20 forward arm circles, 20 backward, and 10 shoulder rolls each way.

0:04–0:09 · Mobility, one minute each

Easy throughout

1. **Cat-camel**, 10 slow cycles, moving one vertebra at a time.
2. **Open-book rotation**, 8 each side, lying on your side with knees stacked.
3. **Wall or post slides**, 10. Forearms on the post, slide up without letting the ribs flare or the elbows leave the surface.
4. **Wrist rocks**, 60 s. Palms down on the bench, rock forward and back, then flip to backs of hands. The weapon hand earns this.
5. **Hip flexor lunge stretch**, 30 s each side, back glute squeezed so the stretch lands in the front of the hip and not the low back.

0:09–0:13 · Activation, two rounds of two minutes

2 × 90 s work / 30 s rest

- 20 s dead hang
- 8 scapular pull-ups — arms stay straight, shoulder blades do all the work
- 12 glute bridges
- 6 bird-dogs each side, three-second hold, a water bottle balanced on the low back if you want honest feedback

0:13–0:25 · Block A — Pull

4 × 90 s work / 90 s rest

Four rounds of three minutes. Work through the three movements, then rest what is left of the round, usually about 90 seconds.

- **5 pull-ups**, strict, chin clearly over the bar, full hang at the bottom.
- **8 inverted rows** on a low bar or the underside of a rail, heels on the ground, body dead straight, chest touching.
- **15 band pull-aparts**, arms straight, slow return.

Easier: pull-ups become 4 negatives, five seconds down each. Or feet-supported rows on a waist-high bar. Harder: pause one second at the top of every pull-up, or add a two-second lower.

Count every strict pull-up you complete across all four rounds. That total is the marker.

0:25–0:37 · Block B — Press and anti-rotation

4 × 100 s work / 80 s rest

Four rounds of three minutes, same structure: work, then rest the remainder.

- **10 push-ups**, elbows at about 45 degrees, body rigid from heel to head. Feet on the bench to make them harder, hands on the bench to make them easier.
- **8 dips** on the bench edge or parallel bars, shoulders staying down.

- **10 Pallof presses each side.** Band anchored at chest height on a post, stand side-on, press the band straight out and hold two seconds. The band is trying to rotate you. Do not let it. This is the most fencing-specific thing in the session and the one most often rushed.

0:37–0:47 · Block C — Trunk ladder



2 × 240 s work / 60 s rest

Two rounds of five minutes. Move straight from one movement to the next, then take the last minute of the round as rest.

- **Hollow hold**, 40 s. Low back pressed flat. Bend the knees or bring the arms down to the sides to make it hold-able for the full 40.
- **Side plank with reach-through**, 30 s each side, threading the top arm under the body and back up.
- **10 hanging knee raises**, no swing. Lying leg raises if the bar is a problem.
- **10 dead bugs each side**, very slow, exhaling as the leg lowers.
- **12 back extensions** face-down over the bench, stopping level — no arching past straight.

Record the longest hollow hold you kept genuinely flat.

0:47–0:54 · Block D — Fencing transfer



4 × 90 s work / 15 s rest

Four rounds of 1 minute 45 seconds. Before you start, pick a target on the post at your own chest height and commit to it: a bolt head, a knot in the bark, the corner of a sign. A cone balanced on the bench back works too. It has to be small — a target the size of your fist teaches nothing.

- **45 s en garde isometric hold.** Weight even, back knee out over the back foot, weapon arm up in line. This should start to burn at about 25 seconds.
- **45 s point control.** From that en garde, extend and touch the target, recover, repeat. Aim for 20 clean touches in the 45 seconds. Speed is not the goal until the target is hit every time.
- 15 s to shake out the arm before the next round.

0:54–0:57 · Finisher — grip



3 × 30 s work / 30 s rest

Three rounds: 30 seconds of dead hang or a 30-second loaded carry with two full water bottles or a loaded bag, then 30 seconds rest. Grip is the one thing in this session that shows up in the fencing hand within a week.

0:57–1:00 · Cool-down



Easy throughout

Child's pose 45 s, pec stretch against the post 30 s each side, wrist flexor and extensor stretch 20 s each, then a minute of slow breathing lying on your back with your calves up on the bench.

Log line

date · 02 core+upper · who · pull-ups total __ · hollow hold __ s · point touches __/20 · felt __/10